

BRENDA ONG

Head of Communications · Crisis & Issues Management · Media Relations · Executive Communications

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SUMMARY

Communications leader with six years' experience running communications for a 15,000-person national institution, including two as its official spokesperson, across a 13-year career in law enforcement, INTERPOL and frontier technology. Owns the full remit: media relations, crisis and issues management, thought leadership, executive visibility, internal communications, and digital/social strategy. Approved 1,000+ news releases and led 25+ major press conferences annually; countered 20+ disinformation campaigns; managed a \$5M communications budget and a 28-person team; grew owned social to 1.3M+ followers. Briefed Reuters, AFP, Bloomberg and CNA. MIT Sloan MBA with hands-on AI governance and LLM evaluation work - fluent in translating complex technology into public language.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Communications Strategy · Media Relations · Organisation Spokesperson · Crisis & Issues Management · Reputation Management · Thought Leadership · Executive Visibility & Media Training · Internal & Employee Communications · Counter-Disinformation · Social & Digital Media Strategy · Communications Measurement & Analytics · Global / Cross-Cultural Communications · Public Affairs & Government Relations · AI Policy Translation · Budget & Agency Management · Team Leadership

COMMUNICATIONS LEADERSHIP HIGHLIGHTS

- Official spokesperson for a national institution of 15,000; communications strategy sustained a record 96% public trust rating.
- Led 25+ major press conferences annually, including fatal officer-involved shootings and national crisis incidents.
- Ran inter-government crisis communications cells countering 20+ disinformation and smear campaigns.
- Briefed international wire and broadcast media including Reuters, AFP, Bloomberg and CNA on national incidents.
- Managed a \$5M annual communications budget, a 28-person team and 1.3M+ owned social followers at 6% engagement.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

HOME TEAM SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY AGENCY (HTX), Singapore

Jul 2025 – Present

Principal Scientist, Disruptive Technologies Office (AI & Emerging-Technology Positioning and Executive Communications)

- Lead 8 executive workshops with 40+ senior leaders, converting emerging-AI strategy into 6 funded, communicable programmes.
- Deliver executive briefings translating a S\$65M+ AI, quantum and space portfolio into mission language for agency leadership.
- Prototyped an LLM behaviour-drift dashboard and public-sentiment forecasting tool for policy announcements.
- Convene industry, academic and government partners as ecosystem liaison, building the external narrative for emerging-tech adoption.

LYMEALERT, Boston, MA

Jun 2023 – Jul 2025

Co-Founder, Chief Operating Officer & Chief Marketing Officer (Brand, Marketing and External Communications)

- Owned brand, marketing and go-to-market communications for a pre-seed biotech, supporting US\$5M+ in startup financing.
- Built a stakeholder engagement framework spanning healthcare policymakers, industry bodies and government agencies.
- Defined pricing, positioning and commercial narrative, advancing 20+ partnership and distribution discussions.
- Cut manual reporting 66.7% (~10 hours/week) by automating leadership reporting across 5 workstreams.

SINGAPORE POLICE FORCE, Singapore

2013 – 2025

Assistant Director, Public Communications Division - Official Force Spokesperson (Feb 2021 – May 2023)

- Directed all external communications for a 15,000-officer national institution; communications programme sustained a record 96% public trust rating.
- Approved 1,000+ news releases, 1,600+ media responses and 90+ proactive features annually, holding message discipline at national scale.
- Led 25+ major press conferences a year as primary media liaison, fronting crisis incidents and flagship policy announcements.
- Led 9 proactive policy-communications campaigns explaining contested operational decisions - use of force, legislative change, response protocols, station relocations - to general audiences.
- Translated legally and technically complex decisions into accessible media briefs with policy, technical and community stakeholders, amplified 3X.
- Commanded inter-government crisis communications cells, countering 20+ coordinated disinformation and smear campaigns.
- Cut misinformation mean-time-to-detection over 50% to 3 hours using social-listening tooling and rules-based alerting.
- Grew owned social from baseline to 1.3M+ followers across five platforms; launched TikTok from zero to 300,000 in a year.
- Founded a 10-person New Media Unit publishing 5+ original content pieces weekly, creating a social-first capability from scratch.
- Media-trained and prepared the police C-suite for press conferences and town halls on a six-month leadership cadence.

- Founded a force-wide employee advocates programme, amplifying policy briefs 3X through officer-influencers and social networks.
- Programme-managed the Police Communications Masterplan, securing Ministry-wide buy-in for a new communications operating model.
- Owned internal communications for ~15,000 officers, sustaining above 75% employee engagement on internal pulse surveys.
- Managed and developed a 28-person communications team running a 24/7 operation at 100+ incidents daily and a 99% response SLA.
- Briefed and maintained working relationships with international wire and broadcast media - Reuters, AFP, Bloomberg and CNA - on national incidents.
- Ran media monitoring and measurement on Meltwater, Truescope and Echosec plus an in-house workflow, reporting sentiment and share of voice to leadership.
- Managed a \$5M annual communications budget, delivering the majority of reach through organic earned and owned channels.
- Authored 20+ forum-page letters and 100+ official statements for the Singapore Police Force, correcting the public record.

Head of Operations & Divisional Media Officer, Tanglin Police Division (Aug 2019 – Feb 2021)

- Served as divisional spokesperson on all operational issues, handling media queries and on-scene press for incidents and major security events across the Division.
- Commanded 30+ major security operations including Formula 1, aligning stakeholders to security aims, like media, tourism board, race promoter and private security.
- Managed S\$10M in annual resources for a 1,500-officer division, releasing 3,200 officer-hours through deployment redesign.

Deputy Team Leader, Crisis Negotiation Unit - concurrent (Jul 2017 – May 2023)

- Deployed as specialist negotiator on threat-to-life incidents, applying structured de-escalation and behavioural risk assessment.

Commanding Officer & Divisional Media Liaison, Bukit Panjang Neighbourhood Police Centre (Jan 2018 – Aug 2019)

- Acted as divisional media liaison and communications officer, fielding press queries and issuing statements on local incidents.
- Commanded 88 officers and cut five major offence categories 30% through data-led deployment planning.
- Co-authored an AI ethics policy paper feeding Singapore’s national AI Governance Framework and Advisory Council.

Operations Officer, Future Operations Division (Jan 2015 – Jan 2018)

- Founded a futures and technology-policy unit, raising pilot-to-adoption conversion from 10% to 50% across six trials.
- Programme-managed a 10-year joint technology masterplan, cutting duplicative systems 42.9% across the force.

Investigation Officer, Central Police Division (Jun 2013 – Jun 2014)

- Solved 20+ investigations monthly while sustaining case solvability above 85%.

INTERPOL GENERAL SECRETARIAT, Lyon, France

Jun 2014 – Jan 2015

Executive, Strategic Planning Directorate

- Authored INTERPOL’s Environmental Scan series forecasting law-enforcement challenges across 195 member countries.
- Produced executive mission briefs preparing INTERPOL’s Secretary-General for international engagements.

SINGAPORE PRESS HOLDINGS, Singapore

Jan 2008 – Jun 2008

Journalist (Internship), The Straits Times - Money Desk

- Published 50+ articles on the financial news beat for Singapore’s national daily newspaper.

EDUCATION

MBA, Sloan Fellows Program - MIT Sloan School of Management	2024
<i>ASEAN Fellow · Specialisation in Business Analytics; coursework in AI & Machine Learning · GPA 4.9/5.0</i>	
MA, Security Studies - Georgetown University, School of Foreign Service	2012
<i>Outstanding Academic Achievement · Concentration: International Security · GPA 3.89/4.0</i>	
BA (Hons, First Class), Politics, Psychology & Sociology - University of Cambridge	2011
<i>Kerslake Scholar, Emmanuel College; Awarded Honorary MA in 2015</i>	
MTech in AI Systems (in progress) - National University of Singapore, ISS	2026 – present

CERTIFICATIONS, SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Certifications: Google Analytics Individual Qualification (2023) · Digital Marketing Bootcamp, Vertical Institute (2023) · Google Data Analytics Professional Certificate (2022) · Data Science Professional, DataCamp (2024) · AI Security, Lakera (2024) · AI Nanodegree, Heicoders Academy (2023) · Certified ScrumMaster (2023).

Tools & Skills: Meltwater, Truescope, Echosec (media monitoring and social listening) · Communications analytics and reporting · SQL, Python, R, Tableau, Power BI · AI-assisted workflows (LLMs, Claude Code, Codex) · Counter-disinformation frameworks · Crisis playbooks and escalation protocols.

Board & Service: Honorary Secretary (Board Member), POLWEL Cooperative Society (2022 – present). The Commendation Medal (COVID-19), Prime Minister’s Office, Singapore (2023).

Languages: English (native) · Mandarin Chinese (native) · French (basic)